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ON THE MAT
Candidates at an Agnipath test training camp in Patna, Jul. 7

450,000
NO. OF CANDIDATES WHO HAD CLEARED THE IAF CASB WRITTEN TEST FOR AIRMEN, NOW REDUNDANT

50,000
NO. OF JAWAN CANDIDATES WHO HAVE PASSED THEIR PHYSICAL/ MEDICAL TESTS FOR THE ARMY. INVALID NOW

80,572
NO. OF JAWANS INDUCTED IN 2019-20 BY THE ARMY, THE LAST TIME RECRUITMENT HAPPENED

an age of soldiers from 32 to 26 years in the next seven years.

The military has been facing the problem of ageing soldiers ever since it extended colour service in the 1970s. Indeed, when the Kargil war happened, many of the jawans were in their late 30s. Lt Gen. Anil Puri, additional secretary in the department of military affairs, says, "The Kargil Review Committee and the Arun Singh Committee had raised objections then on the average age of soldiers."

Another motivation may be to reduce the pension bill—for FY 2022-23, this is Rs 1.2 lakh crore of the Rs 5.25 lakh crore defence budget.

An INDIA TODAY investigation has found that the abrupt announcement of the Agnipath scheme has thrown the future of over 500,000 military aspirants who have cleared the written exams into uncertainty. While 7,000 candidates were waiting for the final list (after going through the entire selection process), over 450,000 candidates have cleared the written test organised by the Central Airmen Selection Board, the recruiting agency for the air force. Similarly, in the Indian army, close to 50,000 candidates from across the country have passed their physical and medical tests.

Upset with the government's move, some candidates have approached the courts for redress while simultaneously gathering support from the political parties to take up the issue in the upcoming monsoon session of Parliament. Among the aspiring airmen, a group of 33 candidates has approached the Supreme Court, while another bunch of 926 has moved the Delhi High court against the government's 'arbitrary' move. They want the IAF Central Airmen Selection Board (CASB) notification dated 11.12.2019 to remain